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EDITION 2027

The Whole Algarve

The honest guide to visiting and living here

by Algarve Newsletter



Photo: Vitor Oliveira / CC BY-SA 2.0

0

BEFORE YOU START

How to use this guide

Who writes it and what it doesn't sell, how it was made, what the marks mean, and what to do when you find a mistake.

I was born in Portimão and brought up here, and thirty years on I
still live here.

That is where this guide starts, and it is also its limit. Nobody knows sixteen municipalities the way they know their own town, and I don't pretend to. So this guide was not written from memory. It was put together from sources you can check, and where a source was silent, the page says so.

These pages say who is behind it, how it was made and how to read it. If you read only one part, read “What the marks mean”.

In this chapter	Who writes · how it was made · how it is organised · what the marks mean · words and conventions · mistakes and updates
The guide	The Whole Algarve · Edition 2027 · by Algarve Newsletter
Covers	All 16 municipalities of the Algarve, and the twelve months
Checked	September and October 2026; each chapter gives its own month at the foot
Paid for by	The people who buy it. No sponsors, no affiliate links
Corrections	algarvenewsletter.pt/guide/changelog
Found a mistake?	algarvenewsletter.pt/guide/report · hello@algarvenewsletter.pt

Who writes this T R P

The guide is published by Algarve Newsletter, a free email in English about the Algarve that goes out on Mondays and Fridays. It is written from Portimão, by someone born and brought up there.

- **What this guide doesn't sell.** Nobody paid to be in it. It has no sponsors and no affiliate links: nothing you book, buy or visit because of these pages earns us anything, unless you go on to one of our own two sites, which the next point describes. We accepted no free meals, rooms or tickets.

- **What our other work does sell**, so that you can weigh it. The newsletter is paid for by local sponsors, who are named as such, and its website carries affiliate links to a tour-booking site. Our events site, Algarve Atlas, has a paid tier. Chapter 41 lists both among its resources and says they are ours.
- **“I” and “we”**. The box that opens each chapter is one person talking. The day it proposes is put together from the chapter’s own sources, like everything else: outside Portimão it is a plan, not a memory. The rest mostly says “we”, because it is the work of the sources as much as of the writer.

How it was made T R P

Each chapter was built from public sources: the town halls, the state’s own pages, the regional and national press, published guides, timetables and price lists. Then every chapter was read a second time against those sources, line by line, and corrected.

- **We have not been to every place in it**. No verdict here claims a visit. The next section says what a verdict is made of.
- **Nothing is invented**. A price, a time, a rule or a date is here because a source gave it, and many carry the month in which we read them.
- **Where we couldn’t find out, we say so**. Each chapter ends with a box called “The honest bit”, which lists what that chapter doesn’t know.
- **Festivals and fairs**. If the 2027 date had been announced when we checked, we give it. If not, we say so and give the 2026 date. The one exception is Easter and the feasts that move with it, whose 2027 dates come from the church calendar. Otherwise we never work out a future date from a past one.
- **Photographs** are real, of the place named, and either under a free licence or in the public domain. The photographer and the licence are beside each one. None is ours.
- **Maps** are drawn for this guide from OpenStreetMap and the state’s boundary data, both credited in Chapter 41.

How it is organised T R P

Start with Chapter 1 if you don't know the Algarve, and with the chapter of your own town if you do.

PART	CHAPTERS	WHAT IS IN IT
I • Orientation	1 to 4	The region in twenty minutes, when to come, where to stay, how many days
II • Logistics without surprises	5 to 8	Getting here, hiring a car, doing without one, money and safety
III • The sixteen municipalities	9 to 24	One chapter each, from Aljezur in the west to Alcoutim in the east
IV • Themes in depth	25 to 31	Beaches, the outdoors, eating, culture, the calendar, families, the honest Algarve
V • Living in the Algarve	32 to 39	Paperwork, home, health, cars, money and tax, everyday life, fitting in, the resident's year
VI • Tools	40 to 42	Phrases and glossaries, maps and resources, the indexes

- **Three kinds of reader.** Beside most section titles there is a mark: T for visitors, R for people from abroad who live here, P for Portuguese readers. A section with one mark was written for that reader; the others can skip it.
- **Every municipality chapter has the same order:** towns and villages, beaches (the nearest ones, where there is no coast), eating, markets, festivals, nature, heritage, living there, and where to stay. Faro and Tavira add a section on boats.
- **The verdicts are given in the municipality chapters.** The chapters of Parts I and IV gather what those say and send you to the page; they add no verdicts of their own.

What the marks mean T R P

A verdict answers the question you would ask a friend: is it worth going? There are no stars and no scores out of five.

MARK	NAME	WHAT IT MEANS
◆◆◆ Worth the trip	Worth the trip	Plan a day around it. At most three in a municipality
◆◆ Worth a detour	Worth a detour	Go if you are within half an hour
◆ If you're nearby	If you're nearby	Pleasant, but don't cross the Algarve for it
✕ Skip it	Skip it	Not worth your time or money. The reason is always given

- **A verdict is a judgement made from evidence**, and not the report of a visit. We weighed what published guides and the national and regional press say of a place, and what thousands of visitors wrote about it, against four questions: is there anything like it nearby, how good is it, what does it cost in time and money, and does it serve the people who live here.
- **No verdict without two independent sources**. A place with fewer is described and left unmarked. Pharmacies, public offices and bus stops are unmarked: they are here to be useful, not to be judged.
- **The top mark needs more**: a strong published source as well, and no more than three places in a municipality may hold it.
- **We print no ratings**, ours or anyone else's. We read what visitors wrote on Tripadvisor and Google, but a number out of five doesn't answer the question. Where a chapter says how a place is reviewed, it says it in words, or counts the low scores among the latest reviews and names the platform.
- **The verdict belongs to the place, not the month**. Where the season changes it, the text says so.

The tags

TAG	NAME	WHEN IT IS GIVEN
▼ Locals' pick	Locals' pick	Many of its reviews are in Portuguese, or the local press writes about it, or our events site lists it as a local find
⌘ Good off-season	Good off-season	Worth going between November and March. Where the place keeps hours, it is open all year and we confirmed them
↑ Rainy-day option	Rainy-day option	Indoors, or worth it in bad weather
■ Easy with kids	Easy with kids	Access, toilets, safety, and enough to hold a child's attention
↔ No car needed	No car needed	Reached by bus, train, boat or on foot from the main town of a municipality

Prices

For a restaurant, the band is one person's main course and a drink, without a bottle of wine, at 2026 prices.

BAND	PER PERSON
€	Up to €15
€€	€15 to €30
€€€	€30 to €50
€€€€	More than €50

Words and conventions T R P

- **Places keep their Portuguese names**, with the accents: Loulé, Olhão, São Brás de Alportel. Chapter 40 says how to pronounce them.
- **A municipality** is a *concelho*: a town and the country around it, run by a town hall, the *Câmara Municipal*. The Algarve has sixteen. Each is divided into parishes, *freguesias*, each with its own small council, the *Junta*.
- **Barlavento and Sotavento** are the western and eastern halves of the Algarve. **The barrocal** is the limestone country behind the coast, and **the serra** is the hills behind that. Chapter 1 explains all four.
- **Prices are in euros and are those of 2026**, with the month we read them where it matters. Expect them to have risen.
- **Opening hours change with the season**, and some places close for part of the winter. Where a source gave winter hours we print them; where it didn't, ring before a long drive.
- **Driving times** come from Google Maps or, in a few places that say so, from a route planner. Take them as a guide.
- **Web addresses are printed without "https://"**. If one doesn't open, put "www." in front of it (Chapter 41).
- **"Last checked"** at the foot of each chapter is the month in which that chapter's facts were last read against their sources.

Mistakes and updates T R P

Some of what is printed here will be wrong by the time you read it. A restaurant closes, a bus line changes, a fee goes up.

- **Corrections** to this edition are listed at algarvenewsletter.pt/guide/changelog, with the chapter and the date. They are free to read throughout 2027.
- **If you find a mistake**, tell us at algarvenewsletter.pt/guide/report, or write to hello@algarvenewsletter.pt. Say which chapter and section, and where you read the right answer if you can. We check it before we change anything.

- **If you live here and think a verdict is wrong**, say that too, and why. The best of those letters will shape the next edition.
- **The next edition.** The guide is dated because it is meant to be redone each year. We have not yet decided how the 2028 edition will be offered to people who bought this one.

The honest bit

- **This is one person's guide and many sources' work.** The writer knows Portimão from the inside and the other fifteen municipalities as a neighbour does.
- **A verdict is not a visit.** It is as good as the sources behind it, and where they were thin there is no verdict.
- **Checking twice doesn't make a page right for ever.** Everything here was true to its source in September or October 2026.
- **We have interests of our own:** a newsletter with sponsors and an events site with a paid tier. Nobody who pays either of them gets a verdict for it. One tag, Locals' pick, can rest on our events site's own list of local finds, as the table of tags says.
- **There is no online map and no track file** with this edition. Chapter 41 says where each trail publishes its own.

LAST CHECKED: OCTOBER 2026 · CORRECTIONS:
ALGARVENEWSLETTER.PT/GUIDE/CHANGELOG



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12

PART III · ZONE B · CENTRAL BARLAVENTO AND THE SERRA DE MONCHIQUE

Portimão

A river port with a museum in a sardine cannery, the big sands of Praia da Rocha and Alvor, a lagoon behind the dunes and a racing circuit in the hills.

If you were here with me, we'd be at the door of the museum in the old sardine cannery when it opens at ten, and afterwards we'd walk up the quay to the old iron bridge and eat sardines off the charcoal at lunch, because that is when the best grill is open. In the afternoon we'd drive ten minutes to Alvor, wait for low tide and walk the boardwalk over the dunes to the rock arches of Três Irmãos. You could have Praia da Rocha the next day, for the sand and the swim.

Portimão is the third-largest municipality in the Algarve by population and by tourism: its hotels and larger rentals sold 2.8 million nights in 2025, more than one in eight of the region's. It is a working city on a river, with the full-service hospital of the western Algarve, a resort of apartment towers on the cliff where the river meets the sea, a low-rise village on a lagoon and a hilly, almost empty north.

Best for	A wide beach with everything at hand; the cannery museum and a sardine lunch; Alvor as a family base; boat trips to the caves and up the river to Silves; motor racing; a city that works all year
Skip if	You want a pretty old town or a quiet village. The resort at Praia da Rocha is a line of tower blocks, and the city is plain once you leave the river
Capital of	Grilled sardines and the canning past; the Algarve's biggest beach resort
From Faro airport	49 min by car to Portimão, Alvor or Mexilhoeira Grande, 56 min to Praia da Rocha · the airport bus takes about 1 h 30 to Portimão's bus terminal · trains from Faro take 1 h 12 to 1 h 30
From Portimão	Hospital 8 min · Praia do Vau 9 min · Praia da Rocha 10 min · Alvor 13 min · Mexilhoeira Grande 17 min · Alcalar 17 min · Lagoa 18 min · Silves 23 min · the racing circuit 23 min · Lagos 33 min · Monchique 35 min · Albufeira 37 min
Beaches	About 8 km of coast; eight official bathing waters, all lifeguarded from 1 June to 30 September; six Blue Flags in 2026
Best months	May, June, September and October. In 2026 the sardine season opened in May. In July and August the sands at Praia da Rocha and Vau are packed. In winter the city, the museum and the walks carry on, and Alvor runs at half strength from January to Easter
Population	59,845 (Census 2021), about 78,100 by the end of 2025 (INE estimate) · three parishes · 182 km ²
Don't miss	The Museu de Portimão · sardines at lunch by the old bridge · the Alvor boardwalk to Três Irmãos at low tide



The places in this chapter, numbered as in the text. *Map data © OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL) · boundaries CAOP 2025 © DGT*

Towns and villages T R P

The municipality has three parishes, unchanged by the reforms of 2013 and 2025. Portimão parish holds the city, Praia da Rocha and four in five of the residents. Alvor is the village on the lagoon, with its beaches, the aerodrome and the Penina

golf hotel. Mexilhoeira Grande is half the municipality's area and has 47 people to the square kilometre. About 23,100 foreign residents held permits here at the end of 2025, the third-largest number in the Algarve after Loulé and Albufeira.

1 • Portimão

◆◆ Worth a detour

↑ Rainy-day option

⌘ Good off-season

⇒ No car needed

The city stands on the west bank of the Arade, 2 to 3 km up the estuary from the sea. It grew as a port for dried fruit and then for canned fish, and was rebuilt for tourism from the 1960s. Lonely Planet calls it rough around the edges, a place most visitors only pass through on the way to the beach, and in the same breath praises its long waterfront and its museum. Residents who answer on Tripadvisor's forum say the same two things: the riverside and the old streets behind it are pleasant, and away from the river it is high-rise. Give it half a day.



The quay at Portimão, with the old road bridge on the right. Photo: Vitor Oliveira, CC BY-SA 2.0



The canning hall of the Museu de Portimão in 2021. Photo: Vitor Oliveira, CC BY-SA 2.0

- **Museu de Portimão**

◆◆◆ Worth the trip

↑ Rainy-day option

⌘ Good off-season

⇒ No car needed

: the municipal museum, opened in 2008 in the Feu Hermanos sardine cannery on the quay, which worked from about 1902 to the 1980s. The Council of Europe gave it its Museum Prize for 2010. Lonely Planet ranks it twelfth among the best things to do in the Algarve.

- **What you see:** the room where the fish were headed, with its conveyor and tables, the canning line and a film that several visitors say makes the visit. The first rooms cover the prehistoric tombs of Alcalar, the Romans and the river. Allow an hour to an hour and a half. Of the twenty latest reviews, one complained that many labels are in Portuguese only and two of a curt reception.
- **Hours and prices:** from September to July, Tuesday 14:30 to 18:00 and Wednesday to Sunday 10:00 to 18:00. In August it opens in the evening instead: Tuesday 19:00 to 23:00, Wednesday to Sunday 14:00 to 23:00. Closed Mondays and public holidays. €3, or €4 with Alcalar; €1.50 for over-65s and ages 16 to 25; free on Sundays for residents of Portugal. Rua D. Carlos I. Phone 282 405 230.
- **The riverside** ♦♦ **Worth a detour** ⇄ **No car needed** : a level walk of about 1 km from the old bridge to the museum. It starts at the Largo da Barca, where a ferry crossed before the bridge was built and the grilled-fish houses now stand, and passes the Jardim Visconde Bivar of 1905, the Praça Manuel Teixeira Gomes and the old fish-auction building, which houses the tourist office. A crane of 1948 still stands on the quay.
- **Largo 1.º de Dezembro** ♦ **If you're nearby** : a small garden of 1931 whose benches are faced with tile panels, designed in 1930, showing ten scenes of Portuguese history from the founding of the nation to the Republic. The 18th-century palace behind it is the municipal theatre, TEMPO.
- **Igreja Matriz** ♦ **If you're nearby** : on the high ground of the old town. The earthquake of 1755 left the late-Gothic doorway, carved by masons who had worked on Silves cathedral, and the Manueline holy-water stoups; the rest was rebuilt. Storks nest on the roof. The tourism board lists it as open on weekdays from 10:00 to 12:30 and 15:00 to 19:00; phone 282 422 612 to be sure.
- **Colégio dos Jesuítas** ♦ **If you're nearby** : the Jesuit college and church that fill one side of the Alameda, the main square. Built from 1660 and consecrated in 1707, with a single very high nave. The national heritage register calls it the largest church in the Algarve. Listed as open on weekdays, 08:00 to 12:30 and 15:00 to 18:00.

- **Casa Manuel Teixeira Gomes** ♦ If you're nearby ⬆ Rainy-day option : the house where the writer was born who became President of the Republic in 1923. Two exhibition rooms and part of his library; one reviewer found the panels in Portuguese only. Tuesday to Friday, 10:00 to 12:30 and 14:00 to 17:00; Saturday afternoon. Free. Rua Júdice Biker 1.
- **The market** ♦ If you're nearby ⬆ Rainy-day option : a modern hall of 2007 on Avenida São João de Deus, about 450 m west of the Alameda, with a separate fish hall. A working market, and a good one for anyone with a kitchen. See *Markets and fairs*.
- **The town walls:** fragments between houses. Nothing is signposted.
- **From the quay:** boats leave for the sea caves, up the river to Silves and across to Ferragudo. See *Nature and walks*.
- **Tourist office:** in the old fish-auction building on the riverside. Phone 282 242 620. We found no opening hours.
- **Parking:** the underground car park under the Alameda has 226 spaces, at €2 for the first hour and €16.50 for a day; the one by the town hall charges €2.20 an hour. Street parking on the quay at Largo do Dique is charged on working days in April, May and October, and every day until midnight from June to September.
- **Time needed:** half a day with the museum and lunch.
- **Getting there:** 49 min by car from Faro airport. The railway station is 800 m north of the riverside gardens. Regional buses stop on the riverside in Avenida Guanaré; coaches and the airport bus use the bus terminal beside the station, 1.4 km to the north. Town bus 30 joins the terminal, the station and the quay every half hour on working days, and bus 37 about hourly at weekends.
- **Last checked:** October 2026

2 · Praia da Rocha

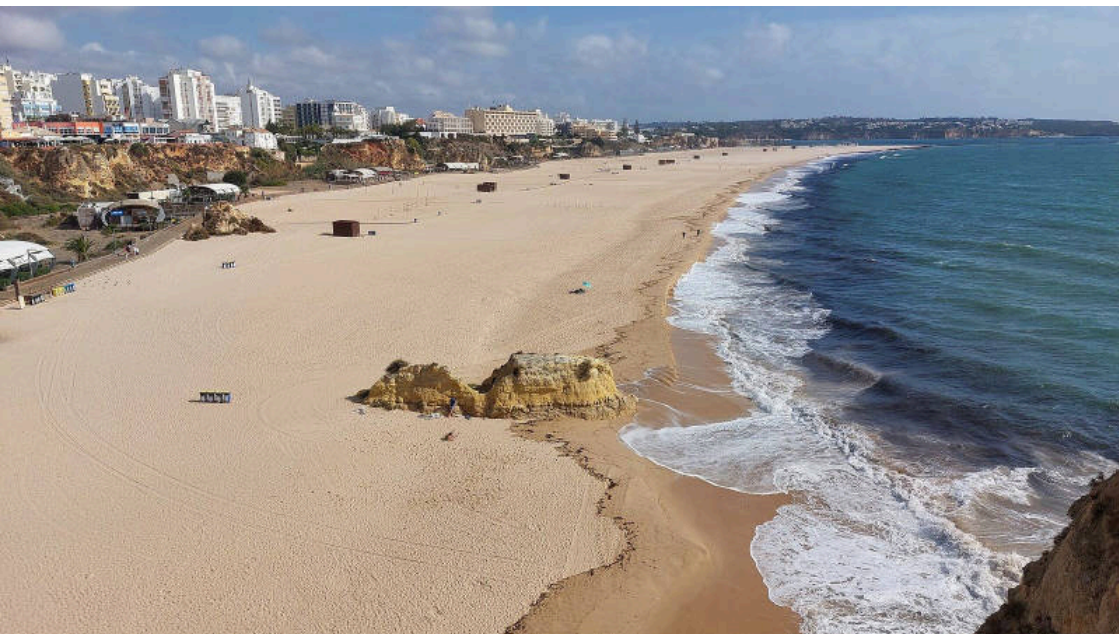
♦ If you're nearby

■ Easy with kids

↔ No car needed

The seaside quarter of the city: one avenue, 1.2 km long, on the cliff top above a very wide beach, with a fort at one end and a viewpoint at the other. A casino opened here in 1910, a grand hotel in 1932, and from the 1970s the cliff-top chalets gave way to apartment towers. Rough Guides ranks the beach sixth in the Algarve and describes the resort as louder and less refined, with buildings that will win no design awards.

Come for the day. Across four threads on Tripadvisor's forums between 2019 and 2026, eight regulars advised against staying here and two were for it. The ones against call it a concrete resort and send people to Alvor, Lagos or Carvoeiro to sleep; several of them add that the beach is lovely.



Praia da Rocha from the Três Castelos viewpoint in November 2025, looking east. Photo: 5R-MFT, CC BY-SA 4.0

- **The beach** ♦♦ **Worth a detour** 🏠 Easy with kids 🚗 No car needed : more than 1 km of sand, lifeguarded, with a Blue Flag, a wooden promenade along its whole length and cafés on it. Lonely Planet names it among the best sheltered, shallow beaches for babies and toddlers. Rough Guides sends families to the end by the fort; one reviewer found the middle the quietest part in high season.
- **Getting down:** the avenue is on the cliff and the sand is below, by staircases. The level way in is at the east end, from the marina. A visitor on a three-week stay never found a step-free access from the avenue.

- Fortaleza de Santa Catarina** ♦ If you're nearby ✱ Good off-season ⇌ No car needed : a fort of the 1630s at the east end of the avenue, built to a design of 1621 to close the river mouth with the fort at Ferragudo opposite. Inside are a small chapel faced with blue tiles and a terrace that looks over the marina, the river mouth and the beach. It is a free viewpoint, with little else to see. Structural repairs ended in June 2026. The staircase from the fort down to the marina was closed in November 2025, and we could not confirm that it has reopened.
- Miradouro dos Três Castelos** ♦♦ Worth a detour ✱ Good off-season ⇌ No car needed : the viewpoint at the west end of the avenue, named for three sea stacks. The place for sunset.
- Praia dos Três Castelos** ♦♦ Worth a detour : the next beach west, below the viewpoint, with stacks, arches and a Blue Flag. It is reached by a long staircase, or along the sand from Praia da Rocha at low tide. A sign warns against sitting under the cliff.
- The marina** ♦ If you're nearby 🏠 Easy with kids : 620 berths at the river mouth, opened in 2000, with a small beach beside it inside the breakwater. Praia da Marina has calm water, level access, lifeguards and a Blue Flag. Many of the cave boats leave from the marina.
- Praia dos Careanos** ♦ If you're nearby : a cove between Três Castelos and Vau, down a steep staircase. It is the one beach here officially classed as of limited use, because the access itself is within reach of falling rock, and the cliff top above it was fenced off after the storms of early 2026.
- The avenue at night:** bars, clubs and a casino in the Hotel Algarve. You will know whether it is for you. A resident on the forum describes the strip as mainly cheap Irish bars, with better places away from the strip and at the marina end.
- Festivals on the sand:** Afro Nation fills the beach for three days at the turn of June and July (3 to 5 July in 2026), with 35,000 to 40,000 people a day. A reviewer in June 2026 described the stages being built at night. If you want a quiet beach, avoid those two weeks.
- Works on the sand:** see *The honest bit*. Expect pipes, machines and closed stretches between here and Vau in the winter of 2026–27.

- **Parking:** stretches of the avenue have been closed to general traffic since 2022. The Rocha Prime underground car park, in Rua D. Martinho Castelo Branco, has 272 spaces and has been open day and night all year since February 2026; a seven-day pass costs €75 from June to September and €50 otherwise. Street parking is free from November to March.
- **Getting there:** 56 min by car from Faro airport, 10 min from the centre of Portimão. Town bus 33 runs every half hour, every day, from the Alameda and the quay to the fort in 15 minutes, between about 07:00 and 20:15; we found no later bus. A single costs €1.75 on board and a day ticket €3.55.
- **Last checked:** October 2026

3 • Vau and João de Arens ♦♦ Worth a detour

West of Praia da Rocha the tower blocks thin out. Praia do Vau is the family beach of the city, and beyond it a wooded headland of a little over a kilometre is the last stretch of this coast without buildings.



The cliffs of João de Arens in December 2024, looking west towards Lagos. Photo: The Cosmonaut, CC BY-SA 2.5 CA

- **Praia do Vau** ♦♦ **Worth a detour** ■ **Easy with kids** : the easy one, level with the road, with ochre cliffs at each end, restaurants behind, a Blue Flag and an amphibious chair for bathers with reduced mobility. It is small, smaller at high tide, and a Portuguese visitor of twenty-five Augusts wrote in 2025 that it gets worse each year. Sunbeds were €15 for half a day and €20 for a day in June 2026.
- **Praia do Alemão** ♦ **If you're nearby** : the official name is Barranco das Canas. A lifeguarded cove under red cliffs next to Vau, with a car park, caves and passages at low tide and no Blue Flag. Invasive seaweed covered much of it in June 2026, and on 16 September 2026 bathing was banned and the beach concession shut until the sand was cleared.
- **The João de Arens walk** ♦♦ **Worth a detour** ✨ **Good off-season** : the Câmara's route *Varandas sobre o Mar* starts at Praia do Vau and follows the cliff top round the Ponta João de Arens towards Prainha, 2.5 km with a variant of the same length. You walk through pine wood above stacks, arches and coves that come and go with the tide. The route sheet asks for great care: the path runs along unfenced edges and past sinkholes, and a man fell from the cliff here in June 2025. Not for small children.
- **The coves below** ♦ **If you're nearby** : Praia de João de Arens and the tiny Praia do Submarino are reached by a scramble down the cliff. Neither is an official beach, so there is no lifeguard. João de Arens is used by naturists; it is not officially designated, whatever some websites say. One visitor took half an hour to find the way down and another gave up the climb as too dangerous.
- **Prainha**: shell-shaped coves west of the headland, reached through a holiday village by a stairway or by a lift that belongs to the resort. The Câmara took it off the official list of beaches in 2022 "for reasons of risk and bathers' safety", and it has no lifeguard. By one newspaper, a man of 64 died on an unguarded part of it on 26 September 2026.
- **Why it is still green**: a plan of 2008 allows hotels on the headland. A scheme for three five-star hotels was refused on environmental grounds in 2019, a smaller one in 2020, and nothing has been built. As far as we could find, the plan itself had not been revoked by October 2026.
- **Getting there**: Vau is 9 min by car from the centre of Portimão and 7 min from Praia da Rocha. Town buses 14 and 35 stop there on working days, and bus 1P at weekends.

- **Last checked:** October 2026

4 • Alvor

◆◆ Worth a detour

■ Easy with kids

↗ No car needed

A fishing village on the east shore of a lagoon, the Ria de Alvor, with streets running down to a harbour and holiday complexes around it. King João II died here in 1495. No guidebook list we read names Alvor, and neither Lonely Planet nor Rough Guides gives it a page, yet it is the place the forum regulars choose: people who have come for twenty years describe a relaxed family village with no loud late-night scene. Much of it is made for British and Irish visitors, and a Portuguese reviewer docked a star for exactly that. There is no monument worth the journey. You come for the boardwalk, the beach and dinner.



Praia in the foreground, the rocks of Três Irmãos and the sand of Alvor behind, in August 2021. *Photo: Joseolgon, CC BY-SA 4.0*

- The boardwalk and the Ria** ♦♦ **Worth a detour** ✨ Good off-season 🏠 Easy with kids
 ⇄ No car needed : about 6 km of raised wooden walkways and earth paths over the dunes and marsh, from the village quay to the breakwater at the mouth of the lagoon and east to Praia dos Três Irmãos. The usual round, out along the beach and back on the boards, takes two hours at an amble. It is flat and suits pushchairs and wheelchairs. There is no shade, there are few toilets and no lights. Dogs must be on a lead, and bicycles are not allowed.
- Praia dos Três Irmãos** ♦♦♦ **Worth the trip** 🏠 Easy with kids ✨ Good off-season : the east end of Alvor's sand, where the dunes give way to cliffs, arches and tunnels that you walk through at low tide into a string of small coves. Rough Guides ranks it eighth among the beaches of the Algarve.
- Três Irmãos in practice:** it has a Blue Flag, lifeguards, beach mats, restaurants on the sand and a car park that cost €3 in August 2026. Check the tide table: at high tide the tunnels are shut. Some reviewers found seaweed in the coves in 2024 and 2025.
- Praia de Alvor** ♦♦ **Worth a detour** 🏠 Easy with kids ⇄ No car needed : about 3 km of level sand between Três Irmãos and the mouth of the lagoon, with two Blue Flags, lifeguards and, at the western half, amphibious chairs and help into the water. It is roomier and windier than the cove beaches. A parasol and two sunbeds cost €20 in September 2026. Swim at the lifeguarded stretches; regulars warn of strong currents between the sandbanks at the river mouth.
- The harbour front** ⇄ No car needed : the fishing quay, the boat kiosks, the old fish-auction building and a row of restaurants. The **lifeboat station** ♦ **If you're nearby** ⬆️ Rainy-day option beside it shows the village's lifeboat of the 1920s. Tuesday to Friday, 10:00 to 13:00 and 13:30 to 16:00; Saturday 10:30 to 13:00 and 14:00 to 16:00; in August, Tuesday to Sunday from 15:00 to 23:00. Free.
- Igreja Matriz** ♦ **If you're nearby** : by the usual account ordered by King Manuel in 1496 in memory of João II; the heritage record dates the building to the 1520s. Its main doorway, carved with foliage, figures and animals, is one of the best pieces of Manueline work in the Algarve. Listed as open every day; phone 282 459 151.
- The castle:** two stretches of an Islamic-period wall, ruined in 1755, with a children's playground inside 🏠 Easy with kids . Open every day, 09:00 to 20:00; free.

- **The morabitos:** three small, domed buildings of Islamic type that became chapels. One is attached to the parish church, one stands by the cemetery and one in Rua de São João. You see them from outside.
- **Skydiving** ♦♦ **Worth a detour** : two centres work from the municipal aerodrome at Montes de Alvor, 5 min from the village. Tandem jumps are from 3,000 m or 4,600 m, the higher one with about a minute of free fall. One centre's list for 2026 gave €179 and €219, and €95 to €165 more for film; reviewers thought the photographs and video expensive.
- **Cars:** since June 2026 the two main streets of the centre are closed to traffic by bollards from 12:30 until 07:00 the next morning.
- **Time needed:** half a day for the boardwalk and Três Irmãos; a week does not bore the regulars.
- **Getting there:** 49 min by car from Faro airport, 13 min from the centre of Portimão. On working days town buses 13 and 14 each run every half hour from Portimão, in 20 to 30 minutes. At weekends bus 1P runs hourly along the beaches, the last from Alvor at 20:30, with more in summer. A forum regular paid about €10 for a taxi to Portimão in October 2025.
- **Last checked:** October 2026



The Alvor boardwalk over the salt marsh, with the village behind. *Photo: Vítor Oliveira, CC BY-SA 2.0*



Alvor's fishing harbour at low tide in January 2024. *Photo: tjabeljan, CC BY 2.0*

5 • Mexilhoeira Grande and the Quinta da Rocha ♦ If you're nearby

Mexilhoeira Grande is a white village just north of the N125 and the railway, the seat of the rural parish. Between it and the lagoon lies the Quinta da Rocha, a peninsula of farmland, marsh and old salt pans between the two arms of the Ria de Alvor.

- **The village:** the Igreja Matriz is an early 16th-century church with a Renaissance doorway and a Manueline chancel arch, listed as open on weekdays. The Misericórdia church keeps four paintings on oak of the late 16th century.
- **The Rocha Delicada trail** ♦ If you're nearby ✿ Good off-season : the Câmara's route round the peninsula, 8 km, circular and easy, on foot or by bicycle, from the railway station. You can bring a bicycle on the train.
- **A Rocha's open morning** ✿ Good off-season : the conservation charity A Rocha has its field centre, Cruzinha, on the peninsula, 7 min by car from the village. Every Thursday from 10:00 to 12:30 it shows visitors bird ringing and moth identification, with coffee and cake between. You are asked to book on its website. We have only the charity's own account of it.
- **Villa Romana da Abicada:** a National Monument, the house of a Roman estate above the lagoon, with rooms round two courtyards. There is little to see. The mosaics were lifted in 2010 and 2011 and are at the Museu de Portimão, where a restoration contract was signed in March 2026. The site has no hours, no ticket and no custodian, and we could not confirm whether it is fenced. Ask the museum before you go.
- **Figueira:** the hamlet east of the village has a producers' market on the first and third Saturday of the month and the cockle festival in September. See *The year in festivals*.
- **Penina:** the hotel and golf course on the N125, in Alvor parish. It opened in 1966 with a course by Henry Cotton, the first in the Algarve, and the agreement on Angola's independence was signed there on 15 January 1975. Seven of the ten latest reviews of the championship course complained of its condition in 2024 and 2025, and one in October 2025 found it in good order: ask before you book.

- **Getting there:** 17 min by car from Portimão, 49 min from Faro airport. The station is 800 m from the church, with nine trains a day each way on working days: Portimão in 9 minutes, Lagos in 9. Bus 80 between Lagos and Portimão stops on the N125 eight times a day on working days and five at weekends.
- **Last checked:** October 2026

6 • Alcalar and the hills ◆ If you're nearby

North of the N125 the land rises towards Monchique through citrus groves, golf courses and scrub. Two things bring visitors: tombs five thousand years old and a racing circuit opened in 2008.

- **Monumentos Megalíticos de Alcalar** ◆ If you're nearby ✿ Good off-season : the burial ground of a walled settlement of the third millennium BC that covered more than 25 ha. Two restored mounds can be visited; one is a tholos, a chamber roofed with a false dome under a cairn, which you enter by a low passage. A small centre shows a film. Reviewers call it well made and brief; one counted fifteen minutes. The finds are in the Museu de Portimão.
- **Alcalar, hours and prices:** from September to July, Tuesday to Saturday, 10:00 to 13:00 and 14:00 to 16:30. In August, to 18:00, and Sundays from 10:00 to 14:00. €2, or €4 with the museum; free on Saturdays for residents of Portugal. Phone 282 248 594.
- **Autódromo Internacional do Algarve** ◆◆ Worth a detour : a circuit of more than 4.6 km in the hills, 13 min from Mexilhoeira Grande. In 2026 it had about twenty race meetings, among them the Superbike World Championship in March, the European Le Mans Series in October and MotoGP on 20 to 22 November. Formula 1 returns on 18 to 20 June 2027, and MotoGP moves to 3 October 2027.
- **On a race weekend:** arrive early and expect a long exit. Reviewers of the November 2025 meeting complained of the crossing of cars and pedestrians at the entrance and of the queues for food.
- **Karting** ◆ If you're nearby : the kart track beside the circuit hires karts every day. Read the terms: one client was charged €200 for damage after a bump in August 2026.

- **Getting there:** Alcalar is 17 min by car from Portimão and 9 min from Mexilhoeira Grande; the circuit is 23 min from Portimão. The only buses are school-time runs on working days. You need a car.
- **Last checked:** October 2026



Monument 7 at Alcalar in 2016. *Photo: Nofafly, CC BY-SA 4.0*



The main grandstand of the Autódromo in April 2024. *Photo: Vitor Oliveira, CC BY-SA 2.0*

Beaches T P

The coast runs for about 8 km between the mouths of the Arade and the Ria de Alvor: cliffs and coves in the east, one long sand in the west. In 2026 there were eight official bathing waters, all lifeguarded from 1 June to 30 September, and six Blue Flags: Marina, Rocha, Três Castelos, Vau and the two halves of Alvor. All eight had the Quercus gold award for water quality. Five are on the national list of accessible beaches, with amphibious chairs at Vau and at the west of Alvor. None is officially naturist. Every cliff beach has a marked strip within reach of falling rock: stay out from under the cliffs. An invasive seaweed lands on this coast in late spring and in autumn and comes and goes with wind and swell.

BEACH		TYPE	GETTING TO THE SAND	FULL ENTRY
Marina	◆ If you're nearby	Calm, in the river	Level	Chapter 25
Rocha	◆◆ Worth a detour	Wide resort beach	Stairs; level at the marina	Chapter 25
Três Castelos	◆◆ Worth a detour	Stacks, arches	A long staircase	Chapter 25
Careanos	◆ If you're nearby	Cove; cliff risk	A steep staircase	Chapter 25
Vau	◆◆ Worth a detour	Family beach	Level; accessible	Chapter 25
Alemão	◆ If you're nearby	Cove, caves	Car park, short walk	Chapter 25
João de Arens	◆ If you're nearby	No lifeguard	A scramble	Chapter 25
Três Irmãos	◆◆◆ Worth the trip	Arches at low tide	Level; mats	Chapter 25
Alvor	◆◆ Worth a detour	Long, level sand	Boardwalk; accessible	Chapter 25

Eat and drink T R P

The local food

- **Sardines:** the Câmara calls Portimão the city of the grilled sardine, and gives the fish a festival every August. The fishery has a closed season: in 2026 it reopened on 4 May, and in 2025 it closed on 3 December. Outside those months what is served is frozen or imported. In the Algarve the boats stay in port from Friday evening to Sunday evening, so the sardines on a weekend plate were landed on Friday or before.
- **Carapaus alimados:** horse mackerel salted overnight, boiled, skinned and boned by hand and dressed with olive oil, vinegar and garlic. A way of keeping fish from before the refrigerator, with deep roots in Alvor.
- **Cockles and oysters:** the cockle of the Ria de Alvor is cooked with rice, with pasta and with maize porridge, and Figueira gives it a festival in September. Oysters from the Ria are served at the town's wine tastings.
- **Wine: Villa Alvor** ♦♦ Worth a detour ↑ Rainy-day option, at Penina, is an estate of 86 ha that the Aveleda group bought in 2019. It offers four tastings every day by reservation, of three to seven wines, on a terrace over the vines. Prices are not published. Phone 282 476 866.

Where to eat

The Michelin Guide 2026 lists three restaurants here: Vista, with one star, and two recommended without one. The best value and nearly all the Portuguese customers are in the old centre of the city and on the avenues behind it, where many houses close on Sundays and some serve lunch only. On the avenue at Praia da Rocha the exceptions are upstairs or a street back. In Alvor the well-reviewed rooms are small and open for dinner. Tripadvisor's ranking for Alvor measures British and Irish taste: thirteen of its top fourteen are not Portuguese restaurants.

The Rota do Petisco, the tapas trail that began in Portimão and spread across the Algarve, has not been held since 2023.

Three habits will save you money here: send back bread and starters you did not ask for; ask the price per kilo of any fish sold by weight and watch it weighed; and carry cash for the small houses.

The Michelin tables

- **Vista** (Bela Vista Hotel, Avenida Tomás Cabreira, Praia da Rocha)
◆◆◆ Worth the trip €€€€: one Michelin star under João Oliveira, and in 2025 and 2026 a platinum fork from *Boa Cama Boa Mesa*, one of five in the country in 2026. Twenty seats in an early 20th-century palace above the beach; two tasting menus, one of fish and shellfish from this coast and one vegetarian. Fourteen of the fifteen latest reviews gave five stars and the other gave four. Dinner only, Tuesday to Saturday. It closes for part of the winter, and we found neither the dates nor the menu prices. Book on 282 460 280.
- **Restaurante F** (Edifício Falésia, Avenida Tomás Cabreira, Praia da Rocha)
◆◆ Worth a detour ⇌ No car needed €€€: up a staircase from the avenue, with a glazed terrace over the beach. Recommended by Michelin, which singles out the octopus cataplana with sweet potato. One party was turned away as full in September 2026 while the booking system showed tables. Ask for a window. Phone 919 115 512.
- **DUOO Gastro Theatre** (Rua Dr. João Vitorino Mealha 10, Portimão)
◆◆ Worth a detour ⇌ No car needed €€€: twelve seats at a counter facing the kitchen of a chef couple, opened in March 2025 and recommended by Michelin. Two tasting menus on Portuguese produce with Spanish and Latin American ideas; the eight-course menu was €65 in 2025. Closed Sundays and Mondays. Phone 933 964 447.
- **NUMA** (Avenida Miguel Bombarda 17, Portimão) ◆◆ Worth a detour
⌘ Good off-season ⇌ No car needed €€€€: the city's own tasting-menu room, opened in 2021 by a chef who left civil engineering for the kitchen; none of the fifteen reviews we read gave fewer than four stars. *Time Out* gave €75 and €90 for its two menus in 2024. Dinner only; closed Sundays. Phone 282 432 454.

Sardines by the old bridge

The grill houses are in the Largo da Barca, the square behind the old road bridge, and on the quay between the two bridges. The complaint that recurs is bread, butter, olives and cheese put on the table unasked and charged item by item: send back what you do not want.

- **Ú Venâncio** (on the quay between the bridges) ♦♦ **Worth a detour** ♥ **Locals' pick**
 ↗ No car needed €€ : an open charcoal grill, a family serving and a view of the river. Twelve of the fifteen reviewers we read were Portuguese, and four of them called these the best sardines in Portimão. Two found it dear. Lunch only; closed Mondays. Phone 282 423 379.
- **Taberna da Maré** (Largo da Barca 9) ♦♦ **Worth a detour** ♥ **Locals' pick**
 ↗ No car needed €€ : a rustic tavern praised for its razor-clam rice, marinated baby squid and stews more than for its sardines, which one reviewer in June 2026 found small, over-salted and €14.50 without salad. Closed Mondays. Phone 282 414 614.
- **Also there** ♦ **If you're nearby** : **Dona Barca**, in the square since 1980 and the name everyone knows, where regulars still praise the grill and a couple were billed three portions of sardines for two in September 2026: read the bill. **Peixarada**, open every day, puts down starters and charges them. **Faina**, the restaurant of the museum, further down the quay, for lunch after the visit; closed Mondays.

Portimão

- **Maria do Mar** (Rua Direita 89) ♦♦ **Worth a detour** ⚙ Good off-season ↗ No car needed
 € : a small kitchen that cooks only from Portuguese canned fish, in the town that lived from canning, with the tins for sale on the walls. Fourteen of the fifteen latest reviews gave five stars. Lunch only; closed Sundays. Expect to wait. Phone 282 094 104.
- **O Viriato** (Avenida São Lourenço da Barrosa, towards Praia da Rocha)
 ♦♦ **Worth a detour** ♥ **Locals' pick** €€ : a family house; eight of the fifteen reviews we read were Portuguese and all were content. Razor-clam rice, grilled tuna and, for the Portuguese, the francesinha. Closed Tuesdays. Book on 967 625 775.
- **Zizá** (Rua Júdice Fialho 20) ♦♦ **Worth a detour** ♥ **Locals' pick** ⚙ Good off-season
 ↗ No car needed €€ : the cataplana house of the old centre, with few tourists. Order fish. Closed Sundays. Phone 966 828 566.
- **Teresinha** (Rua Direita 97) ♦♦ **Worth a detour** ♥ **Locals' pick** ⚙ Good off-season
 ↗ No car needed € : the dish of the day, served in minutes to a room full of locals; one reviewer is the fourth generation of his family to eat there. Closed Sundays. Phone 282 425 690.

- **Churrasqueira Guerreiro** (Rua de São Pedro 13) ♦♦ Worth a detour ▼ Locals' pick
⚡ Good off-season €: piri-piri chicken, home-cut chips and salad; one customer paid €14.60 for the lot with wine in June 2026. A queue at lunch. Closed Mondays. Phone 282 412 742.
- **Cervejaria Lúcio** (Largo Francisco António Maurício) ♦♦ Worth a detour ▼ Locals' pick €: an old-fashioned beer house for very fresh shellfish, goose barnacles above all. *Mesa Marcada's* 2026 guide notes that it has no photographs of dishes at the door and that tourists walk past it. Four of the fifteen reviewers disliked the owner's manner. Closed Mondays. Phone 282 424 275.
- **A Casa da Isabel** (Rua Direita 61) ♦♦ Worth a detour ▼ Locals' pick
↑ Rainy-day option ⇄ No car needed €: a tea room for regional sweets and home-made cakes. Eight of the fifteen reviewers were Portuguese and all were pleased.
- **O Quinto Império** (Avenida João Paulo II, Vale de França) ♦♦ Worth a detour
⚡ Good off-season €: a short Portuguese menu on a residential avenue away from the sea front. Closed Sundays. Phone 282 074 993.
- **Cozinha de Sónia** (Rua Alexandre Herculano 32) ♦♦ Worth a detour €: Indian home cooking, vegetarian and vegan, with fifteen five-star reviews out of fifteen. Closed Mondays. Phone 920 252 280.
- **Also good** ♦ If you're nearby : **O Mata Porcos** €, a family tasca for pork and stewed cuttlefish; **Café Brasil**, a shellfish house despite its name; **Pizzeria Volare** €, with a gluten-free base; **Porta Certa** €, on weekdays only, where the full menu was €13.50 in October 2026; and **Casa das Bifanas** €, for a pork roll inside the market.

Praia da Rocha and Vau

- **Servi-Vau** (Avenida São Lourenço da Barrosa) ♦♦ Worth a detour €: a small family house behind the resort, for sardines and home cooking at fair prices. Closed Mondays. Phone 969 504 345.
- **Also good** ♦ If you're nearby : **All Beef**, one street back, for those who do not eat fish, dinner only; **Pronúncia do Norte** €, for northern Portuguese soups and snacks inside an arcade; **Cantinho Português**, on the avenue, which Portuguese visitors rate; **O Rebelo**, a family fish grill on the sand at Vau, by day only.

Alvor

- **Sereia** (Largo da Ribeira 7) ♦♦ **Worth a detour** ⇌ No car needed €€ : a harbour-front fish house with a clean record, and one that Portuguese families return to every year. Fish from the counter and cataplana. Closed Wednesdays. Phone 282 459 323.
- **aTASCAdo** (Rua Pedro Álvares Cabral 2) ♦♦ **Worth a detour** ⇌ No car needed €€ : Portuguese petiscos in a tavern room with a roof terrace over the lagoon; fifteen five-star reviews out of fifteen. Dinner only; closed Sundays. Book on 282 030 688.
- **Tasca Morais** (Rua Dr. António José de Almeida 14) ♦♦ **Worth a detour** ⇌ No car needed €€ : a small, plain family room for fish soup, cataplana and mixed fish, with regulars of fifteen years. Dinner only; closed Sundays. Book on 282 459 392.
- **Dom João** (Rua do Sol 18) ♦♦ **Worth a detour** ⇌ No car needed €€ : large portions of local cooking; six of the fifteen reviewers were Portuguese and none of the fifteen gave fewer than four stars. Closed Tuesdays. Phone 282 458 645.
- **Also good** ♦ **If you're nearby** : **A Lota**, for grilled fish chosen at the counter; **Churrasqueira Mercado de Alvor** €, by the market, for chicken and sardines off the charcoal; **Buganvília**, where the Portuguese share is highest; **Omakase**, a Japanese kitchen with Portuguese customers; **Atlântida** and **O Candeeiro**, on the sand at Três Irmãos. **Zé Morgadinho**, the fishermen's tavern on the harbour, is for sardines and a jug of wine at lunch, out of August: eight of its fifteen latest reviews gave three stars or fewer.

Mexilhoeira Grande and the north

- **Adega Vila Lisa** (Rua Francisco Bívar, Mexilhoeira Grande) ♦♦ **Worth a detour** ♥ **Locals' pick** €€€ : a house of some forty years with no menu. Everyone is served the same sequence of country dishes of the season; *Mesa Marcada* named tuna *estupeta*, cuttlefish with sweet potato and peas, and maize porridge with razor clams. Dinner only; every day from July to September, Fridays and Saturdays only otherwise. Phone 282 968 478.
- **Vila Lisa, the bill**: ten of the fifteen reviewers were Portuguese, some of them customers for thirty years, and five objected that the price is learnt only with the bill: €40 a head in 2024, by one account. Ask when you book.

- **Solar do Farelo** (Várzea do Farelo) **♦♦ Worth a detour** **€€**: a country house a taxi ride from Alvor, a favourite of foreign residents and returning British visitors. Closed Mondays and Tuesdays. Phone 964 080 719.
- **Also good** **♦ If you're nearby** : **A Oficina** **€**, a petisqueira in Mexilhoeira Grande; **O Tasco**, at Senhora do Verde, for a weekday lunch; **Fonte de Pedra**, at Alcalar, where you should check the card slip.

Skip **✕ Skip it**

- **Vinhos & Comidas** (Avenida Tomás Cabreira, Praia da Rocha): eleven of the fifteen latest reviews gave one or two stars, for fish with no price on the menu, bread charged unasked and an 80-minute wait.
- **Restaurante Almeida** (Marina de Portimão): seven of fifteen at one or two stars; one table was nearly charged €50 too much in August 2026.
- **Canico** (Prainha), for a meal: a restaurant built into the cliff above a cove, reached by a lift. Nine of the fifteen latest reviews gave one or two stars, and two diners were charged €145 a kilo for fish in July 2026. Go for a drink and the setting.
- **SeaDeck** and **Dunas** (Praia de Alvor): two hotel beach restaurants. At the first, 10% is added for service; at the second, one bill in September 2026 was €35 too high. Ten and eleven of their fifteen latest reviews gave three stars or fewer.
- **Café na Ria** (Alvor waterfront): fourteen of fifteen at three stars or fewer, for long waits and high prices. The kiosk next to it is the better choice.

Markets and fairs T R P

MARKET	WHEN	WHERE	WHAT YOU'LL FIND
Mercado Municipal de Portimão	Mon to Fri 07:00 to 14:00 and 17:00 to 20:00; Sat 07:00 to 14:00	Avenida São João de Deus	Fish, meat, fruit and vegetables, bread, flowers
Mercado de Alvor	Tue to Sat, mornings	Alvor village	Fish, fruit and vegetables
Portimão monthly market	1st Monday, morning; none in November	Parque de Feiras, by the Arena	Clothes, shoes, household goods, produce, cheese
Portimão flea market	1st and 3rd Sunday, 08:30 to 12:30	Parque de Feiras	Second-hand goods, antiques, books
Mercadinho da Ria	Sundays, from 08:00	Alvor riverside	Regional produce, cheese, honey
Mercadinho da Figueira	1st and 3rd Saturday, 08:00 to 13:00	Figueira	Fruit, honey, liqueurs, sweets, crafts
Organic market	Saturdays, 09:00 to 14:00	Jardim Visconde Bivar, Portimão	Certified organic produce

The flea market has many exceptions: in 2026 it skipped several dates and moved to the riverside from February to April. We found no monthly market in Alvor and no market in the village of Mexilhoeira Grande. The working fish auction is across the river, in Lagoa, and is not open to the public.

The year in festivals T R P

Four 2027 dates had been announced when this edition was checked (October 2026): Afro Nation, Formula 1, the Festival da Sardinha and MotoGP. For the rest, the tables give each event’s rule and its 2026 dates as a reference; check vivaportimao.pt closer to the time. In 2027 Shrove Tuesday is 9 February and Easter Sunday 28 March. The municipal holiday is 11 December.

January to June

WHEN	FESTIVAL	WHAT IT’S LIKE
Shrove Tuesday (2026: 17 February)	Carnival ♥ Locals' pick	Thirteen floats on Portimão's riverside at 15:00, and dances in the clubs all week. Alvor and Mexilhoeira Grande parade on the Sunday. Free
Two Sundays before Easter, and Holy Week	Processions	The procession of the Senhor dos Passos through the city, and Palm Sunday from the Colégio to the Matriz
Last weekend of May (2026: 30 and 31 May)	Fisherman's Day, Alvor	A fair by the old fish auction, and on Sunday morning the fishermen sell their catch direct
June (2026: six nights from 4 to 28 June)	Marchas Populares ♥ Locals' pick	Costumed parades at 21:30, one of them along the avenue at Praia da Rocha and one on the Alvor riverside
18 to 20 June 2027	Formula 1 ♦♦ Worth a detour	The Portuguese Grand Prix returns to the Autódromo, and again in 2028
June or early July (2026: 3 to 5 July; 2027: 9 to 11 June)	Afro Nation	A ticketed music festival on the sand at Praia da Rocha, with 35,000 to 40,000 people a day

July to December

WHEN	FESTIVAL	WHAT IT'S LIKE
Mid-July (2026: 17 to 19 July)	Portimão Wine Tasting	Local wines and oysters inside the fort at Praia da Rocha. Free entry; glass €2
First full week of August (2026: 4 to 9 August; 2027: 3 to 8 August)	Festival da Sardinha ♦♦ Worth a detour ♥ Locals' pick ↺ No car needed	Six nights on the riverside, 18:00 to 01:00. Free
Mid-August (2026: 14 to 16 August)	Nossa Senhora da Boa Viagem, Alvor	A procession and the blessing of the fishing boats on the lagoon. The parish lists it as held every two years
Second weekend of September (2026: 11 to 13 September)	Festival do Berbigão, Figueira ♥ Locals' pick	Cockles with rice, pasta and maize porridge, cooked on the spot. €5
Early October (2026: 3 and 4 October)	afpop expo	The fair of services for foreign residents, formerly called BLiP, at the Portimão Arena. Free
3 October 2027 (2026: 20 to 22 November)	MotoGP ♦♦ Worth a detour	The Portuguese Grand Prix at the Autódromo
Ten days around 11 November (2026: 6 to 15 November)	Feira de São Martinho ♥ Locals' pick ■ Easy with kids	Chestnuts, stalls and fairground rides at the Parque de Feiras
December to 6 January	Christmas; New Year's Eve	A market on the riverside and an ice rink on the Alameda. At midnight, fireworks from the Portimão riverside, the Alvor riverside and the breakwater at Praia da Rocha

The one to plan around. The **Festival da Sardinha** was first held in 1985, and 2026 was its 30th edition. Five local clubs grill the sardines; a plate of five with bread, potatoes and salad cost €12.50. The Câmara counted 145,729 entries at the gates in six nights, a record.

Nature and walks T R

- **The Alvor boardwalk** ♦♦ **Worth a detour** ✧ **Good off-season** ■ **Easy with kids** : see *Alvor*. The lagoon is a wetland of international importance under the Ramsar convention since 1996 and a Natura 2000 site of 1,454 ha, most of it in Portimão. Little terns and black-winged stilts nest in spring and summer; in winter the marsh holds redshank, godwits, avocets and flamingos.
- **Varandas sobre o Mar** ♦♦ **Worth a detour** ✧ **Good off-season** : the cliff-top route round the João de Arens headland. See *Vau and João de Arens*.
- **A Rocha Delicada** ♦ **If you're nearby** ✧ **Good off-season** : 8 km round the Quinta da Rocha from Mexilhoeira Grande station. See *Mexilhoeira Grande*.
- **To Monchique on foot**: a link route of the Via Algarviana climbs from Mexilhoeira Grande station to Monchique (Chapter 15), about 26 km and graded difficult, with a signposted detour to Alcalar.
- **Up the Arade to Silves** ♦♦ **Worth a detour** : a river journey of about 15 km to the castle town (Chapter 14), four to five hours with time ashore, possible only on days when the tide allows. Algarve Sunboat, whose solar boats hold a Blue Flag, and Alvor Boat Trips, which takes nine passengers, are both well reviewed. Reviewers describe herons and flamingos on the way and the old canneries from the water.
- **To the sea caves** ♦♦ **Worth a detour** ■ **Easy with kids** : boats leave from the marina, from the Clube Naval beside the museum and from the riverside quays, so ask which when you book. A trip is about two hours along the coast of Lagoa (Chapter 13) to several caves, of which Benagil is one, and entry is never guaranteed. Benagil Express charges €35, and €20 for children of 3 to 10; Algarve Discovery is well reviewed. Go in the morning for calmer water. The cheapest trip on the booking sites has the worst record, with four in ten reviews at one or two stars: choose an operator with a long, clean one.
- **For small children** ♦ **If you're nearby** ■ **Easy with kids** : the Santa Bernarda, a two-masted replica sold as a pirate ship, sails from the riverside past Carvoeiro and transfers its passengers to small boats at the caves. €35, €25 for ages 11 to 17 and €15 for ages 3 to 10.

- **Dolphins** ♦♦ **Worth a detour** : trips go far offshore, and one reviewer warned of a fast, cold ride. Choose a boat with a marine biologist and ask what happens if none are seen.
- **By kayak from Alvor** ♦♦ **Worth a detour** : Wooden Boat Tours takes a few people along the coast in a small wooden boat and then by kayak into caves east of Alvor.
- **To Ferragudo** ♦♦ **Worth a detour** ⇄ **No car needed** : a water taxi crosses from the marina and from the pier by the museum to the village opposite (Chapter 13) in about ten minutes; reviewers paid €10 return in 2026. It stopped for the winter of 2025–26 and resumed in February.
- **Under water**: four decommissioned navy ships were sunk off this coast in 2012 and 2013 as an artificial reef, in about 30 m of water. It is for certified divers.
- **Golf**: four clubs. Penina, of 1966; Alto Golf at Alvor, Henry Cotton's last design, opened in 1991; and Morgado and Álamos, in the hills on the road to Monchique.

Heritage and stories T P

Sardines in tins. The first cannery in Portimão itself opened in 1892, and the Feu brothers, from Ayamonte across the Spanish border, opened theirs on the riverside in 1902 and sold its sardines under the name La Rose. Canning was at its height during the Second World War and declined afterwards, with fewer fish, old machinery and competition from Morocco. The Feu factory worked until the 1980s; the Câmara bought it in 1996 and opened the museum in it in 2008. Another old cannery by the river, shut for about thirty years, is to become apartments.

A beach made wider. Before the 1960s Praia da Rocha was a small resort of chalets on a cliff. In 1970 the beach was widened with sand dredged from the harbour, to make room for bathers and to keep the sea off the cliff, and it was fed again in 1983 and 1996. In the 1970s the chalets were replaced by towers, and in the 1980s the sea front became an unbroken line of large buildings. Two coastal scientists who studied it in 2012 called it a model of how a coast is turned into something man-made. In 2025 the State began pumping the surplus sand westward to the beaches that lack it.

The president who left. Manuel Teixeira Gomes was born in Portimão in 1860, the son of a dealer in dried figs. He was a writer, the Republic's first envoy in London and, from 1923, its seventh president. Portimão became a city during his term, on 11 December 1924. He resigned a year later, left for Algeria and never came back. He died there in 1941. His house and the riverside square carry his name.

A treaty in a golf hotel. The Penina opened in 1966 on drained rice fields, with a course laid out by the British champion Henry Cotton, who stayed on. On 15 January 1975 Portugal and the three Angolan independence movements signed there the agreement that set the date of Angola's independence. It is known as the Alvor Agreement, after the parish.

If you live here R P

Câmara Municipal	Praça 1.º de Maio, Portimão · 282 470 700 · weekdays, 09:00 to 13:00 and 14:00 to 17:00 · one-stop counter at Rua do Comércio 29–31, 282 470 777, weekdays 09:00 to 17:00
Espaço Cidadão	At the one-stop counter, by appointment · also in the Juntas of Alvor (Monday, Wednesday and Friday) and Mexilhoeira Grande
Immigration	AIMA office at Quinta do Morais, Lote 11; book at contactenos.aima.gov.pt · CLAIM migrant-support desk at the town hall, door 5: Mondays, Tuesdays and Thursdays · 282 248 538
Juntas de Freguesia	Three. Portimão 282 402 140 · Alvor 282 459 326 · Mexilhoeira Grande 282 968 225
Hospital and A&E	Hospital de Portimão, Sítio do Poço Seco · 282 450 300 · the full emergency department for the western Algarve, 8 min from the centre, 14 min from Alvor and 15 min from Praia da Rocha
Before you go with a child or a pregnancy	The maternity and children's emergency have closed for days at a time since 2023: check the SNS website or phone SNS 24 on 808 24 24 24. The fallback is Faro, 53 min away
Health centre	Rua Manuel Dias 1, Portimão · 282 420 160 · a branch at Mexilhoeira Grande, 282 968 133
Private hospital	Hospital CUF Alvor, formerly Hospital Particular do Algarve, on the road to Alvor · 282 420 400 · 24-hour emergency for adults
Fire brigade and police	Bombeiros de Portimão 282 420 130 · PSP 282 078 100 · GNR 282 420 750 · port captain and maritime police 282 073 503 · municipal civil protection 808 282 112 · emergencies 112

Water and rubbish

EMARP, the municipal company · counter at Rua do Comércio 29-31 · 282 400 260 · free home collection of bulky and garden waste on 808 282 260 · ALGAR's recycling yard at Parque Industrial Coca Maravilhas, weekdays 08:00 to 12:00 and 13:00 to 17:00, which doesn't take bulky or garden waste

Schools

Five public school groups. We found no international school in the municipality; the nearest is in Lagoa (Chapter 13)

Higher education

A campus of the Universidade do Algarve and the private institute ISMAT

Learn Portuguese

The job centre listed one state course here in autumn 2026; Chapter 38 has the rest

Foreign residents

afpop, the association of foreign property owners, has its head office here: Rua dos Bombeiros Voluntários, Lote 5 · 282 458 509 · advice in English and German on permits, licences and tax

Public transport

Town buses *Vai e Vem*: €1.75 on board, €3.55 for a day, €14 for seven days · trains to Lagos in 18 min (€2.30) and Faro in about 1 h 15 (€6.80) · for Lisbon, change at Tunes

Library, theatre, work

Biblioteca Municipal, Quinta do Bispo, 282 480 476, closed Sundays and Mondays · TEMPO theatre, 282 402 470 · a municipal co-working room in the old fish auction

Property prices

Median €3,125/m² for homes sold in the year to Q1 2026, up 18.7% in a year, against €3,240 in the Algarve and €2,168 in Portugal (INE) · €3,219 in Alvor and €2,641 in Mexilhoeira Grande · median new rent €11.70/m² in the year to June 2026, the fourth highest in the Algarve (INE)

Local taxes

Tourist tax all year: €2 a night from April to October, €1 from November to March, for the first seven nights, from the age of 13 · IMI 0.37%

Where to stay T

- **For families and a village: Alvor.** A level beach with lifeguards, the boardwalk, restaurants on foot and buses to Portimão. The hotels stand along the beach between the village and Três Irmãos.
- **For a beach on the doorstep: Praia da Rocha,** if you want the sand, bars and everything close and do not mind tower blocks and noise. Two forum visitors were happy with full-board hotel stays there, one of them for three weeks in winter. **Vau** has hotels beside its family beach.
- **For a budget and no car: Portimão** city. Rough Guides picks it as the cheaper base, with the beach a bus ride away, the station and the market.
- **Camping:** Camping Alvor, on the road into the village, is open all year; in 2026 an adult paid €5 to €8 a night and a tent €5.50 to €9.50, by season. We found no campsite in the city and no official motorhome area.
- **Who comes:** seven in ten hotel nights in 2025 were foreign, a quarter of all of them British. Portuguese guests bought more nights here than in any Algarve municipality except Albufeira.

In winter

The museum keeps its winter hours and the market, the churches and the city carry on. The Alvor boardwalk and the cliff walk are at their emptiest. Alvor, by its regulars' account, goes quiet after New Year until about Easter, with enough bars and restaurants open for the people who live there. Vista closes for some weeks. The airport bus drops to two a day each way from November to April, street parking by the beach is free, the tourist tax falls to €1 and the racing calendar runs through the cold months. Between Praia da Rocha and Vau, expect the sand works.

The honest bit

- **Praia da Rocha is a wall of towers above a man-made beach.** The sand is superb and was put there by dredgers. Most forum regulars advise sleeping somewhere else.
- **The sand and the cliffs are being worked on.** From November 2025 to May 2026 the State pumped sand from Praia da Rocha to Três Castelos, Careanos and Vau, closing beaches in turn. The job was left unfinished for the summer and is due to resume. A national plan of July 2026 lists €7 million to stabilise the cliffs between Praia da Rocha and Vau.
- **The big festival is loud.** Afro Nation brings 35,000 to 40,000 people a day to the sand for three days, and the regional press reports noise complaints from Praia da Rocha and from Ferragudo across the river. The Câmara renewed its agreement with the promoters for five years in 2025.
- **The hospital is under strain.** Its maternity and children's emergency have shut on and off since June 2023; the maternity emergency was closed again on 4 April 2026. On 13 August 2026 the national health website showed an average wait of over four hours in A&E.
- **The bridges are a bottleneck.** The N125 bridge over the Arade carries 10,000 to 12,000 vehicles a day and has had works since September 2024. The road to the old bridge on the Lagoa side is being rebuilt for twelve months from 12 October 2026, through the summer of 2027.
- **Housing is dear.** Sale prices rose 18.7% in the year to early 2026, and rents on new leases are the fourth highest in the Algarve. The Câmara pays a rent subsidy to 545 households and has 232 flats for supported rents under contract, none of them finished.
- **Two green places are unsettled.** The plan that allows hotels on the João de Arens headland had not, as far as we could find, been revoked. The Ria de Alvor has European and international protection on paper and no reserve or park of its own; the mayors of Portimão and Lagos signed a letter of intent in February 2026 that names no concrete step.